The Shanghai communiqué that emerged from the visit, with its endorsement of a Chinese role in South Asia, did more than embarrass Delhi. Gandhi criticized its reference to India-Pakistan issues and specifically Kashmir.[249] Kissinger tried to point out to Jha that, "the U.S. formulation was much milder than the Chinese formulation."[250] Kaul told Keating, however, that the US should not have allowed China to include its starker statement.[251] Not only had Kissinger not objected to the Chinese formulation—or tried to change Chinese policymakers' minds about it—he had been open to Chinese views regarding changes to the words the US included on the issue.[252]

Jha acknowledged that the US formulation on the India-Pakistan question was milder. However, he expressed other concerns—specifically that the wording of the communiqué left open the door for US acceptance of Chinese hegemony in South Asia.[253] This was a far cry from Kissinger's assurance a year before that "if the Chinese seek to dominate areas outside their country, or, for instance, dominate India, we cannot connive at this."[254] The Indian ambassador did not mention the concern he expressed to Kaul privately—the possibility that Nixon and Mao had reached a secret understanding about "sphere[s] of influence."[255]

As American officials and intelligence analysts knew, the Indian concern was that China and the US would work together to contain India.[256] As the US was triangulating, Gandhi passed on to Haksar a deputy minister's observation that the US was leaving India "out of calculations about the Asian scene. We were supposed to be at best naughty, clever boys, who could spoil a scene, but could never play a role in the drama."[257] Even American observers like Walt Rostow expressed concern about Nixon's vision of a multipolar world that included China but left out India." He asserted to Kissinger that India needed to be brought "back into the equation of power in Asia."[258]

While Nixon was in China, Gandhi had asserted, "We will not allow China and the USA to decide what should happen in Asia."[259] Now, on the campaign trail in March, Gandhi implied that China and the US wanted to "create trouble" for India. She criticized the US—alone and in conjunction with China—for its support of Pakistan. She said the US was "sitting on China's lap," while Beijing was getting whatever it wanted. She repeated publicly what Jha had indicated to US officials privately: that India